

# Trait Activation Theory: A Review of the Literature and Applications to Five Lines of Personality Dynamics Research

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## Keywords

trait activation, personality dynamics, situational specificity, interactionism, PE fit

## Abstract

Extending interactionist principles and targeting situational specificity of trait–performance linkages, trait activation theory (TAT) posits personality traits are expressed as valued work behavior in response to trait-relevant situational cues, subject to constraints and other factors, all operating at the task, social, and organizational levels. Review of 99 key sources citing TAT spanning 2011–2019 reveals diverse applications (e.g., bidirectionality, trait specificity, team building) and an overall 60% significance rate for 262 TAT-based moderator effects reported in 60 of 75 empirical studies. Applying five key aspects of TAT (e.g., behavior/performance distinction, need-based motivation) to five lines of personality dynamics research (e.g., personality states, self-regulation models of motivation) supports TAT as a vehicle for advancing understanding of within-person variability over brief and extended timelines. Critical research needs include personality-oriented work analysis, longitudinal study of trait-situation processes, trait activation in teams, within-job bidirectionality, and situation relevance as a unifying principle in advancing person–workplace fit.

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## INTRODUCTION

In the middle of the past century, as the field of psychology was coming to terms with the inadequacies of black-box behaviorism, it struggled to determine whether traits or situations are the primary sources of behavioral variance. The person–situation debate resolved in the 1970s in the form of person–situation interactionism (e.g., Bowers 1973, Ekehammar 1974, Endler & Magnusson 1976). The answer was that traits and situations, like two sides of a coin (Eysenck & Eysenck 1985), are inseparable: One cannot talk meaningfully about one without invoking the other. The debate was resolved by realizing it was fundamentally untenable.

Years before that resolution, Guion & Gottier (1965) had summarized approximately a decade of personality applications in the workplace, concluding personality tests could not be recommended for predicting valued organizational outcomes. The low rates of significant effects might have supported a situationist position; however, anticipating the forthcoming reconciliation, Guion & Gottier (1965) cautioned that a trait's value depends on the situation:

In short, it must be concluded (as always) that the validity of any personality measure must be specifically and competently determined for the specific situation in which it is to be used and for the specific purpose or criterion within that situation. (p. 160)

The advent of psychometric meta-analysis in the 1970s (e.g., Schmidt et al. 1979), together with the discovery of a relatively robust taxonomy of five major personality dimensions [the five-factor model (FFM): neuroticism, extraversion, openness, agreeableness, and conscientiousness (e.g., Tupes & Christal 1958)], permitted refined assessment of the value of personality in predicting work outcomes. Barrick & Mount (1991) identified conscientiousness as the best overall predictor and the one most consistently predictive across multiple job families; extraversion was found to be predictive in management and sales. Notable variability in the strength and, in some cases, the direction of validity estimates within broad trait–job family pairings suggested untapped situational specificity.

Soon afterward, Tett et al. (1991) published a meta-analysis on personality–job performance linkages focusing on situational specificity operationalized in terms of confirmatory versus exploratory research strategies. Confirmatory strategies target particular trait–outcome relations based on job analysis, a rationale, and/or prior research, whereas exploratory cases offer no such foundation (essentially crap shoots). In support of situational specificity, mean validity estimates from the confirmatory cases were twice as strong as those from exploratory cases. Moreover, as expected, validity strengthened when confirmatory designs were driven by job analysis. Tett et al. (1999) largely replicated the original results using refined methods.

Given personality validity estimates vary systematically within broad trait–job family and trait–criterion pairings (e.g., Barrick & Mount 1991) and validity is stronger where traits are selected *a priori* in light of local situational contingencies (Tett et al. 1991, 1999), it begs the question as to how this occurs, and, further, whether the process might be leveraged to improve the predictive yields from personality in work settings.

Introduced as a principle for answering those questions, trait activation has been used frequently since publication of two introductory articles. Tett & Guterman (2000) showed trait expressions as intentions are more consistent across situations more similarly trait relevant, and Tett & Burnett (2003) fleshed out a broader conceptual model. Tett et al. (2013) summarized applications up to 2011 and expanded the model in key respects. Extending those efforts, our primary aims here are to (a) articulate the key features of trait activation theory (TAT) and its applications, (b) summarize how TAT has been used in the literature from 2011 to 2019 and its effectiveness as a basis for trait–outcome moderation, and (c) apply TAT in advancing dynamic personality processes in the workplace. We begin with a brief introduction to personality.

## PERSONALITY: A VERY BRIEF INTRODUCTION

Personality captures people's characteristic thoughts, feelings, and behaviors, allowing distinctions among individuals and, to varying degrees, prediction of how they will think, feel, and behave in the future. Individuation and prediction are critical for human survival and reproductive success. Who can be trusted? Who would make a good mate? They are also important in work settings where some job applicants, coworkers, and teammates are chosen over others as likely to perform well. Personality covers a broad range of individuating proclivities potentially relevant to valued organizational outcomes. Given increasing competition for human capital (e.g., Gardner 2005, Shaw et al. 2013), it is hardly surprising personality has become a popular target of organizational research (e.g., LePine et al. 2011, Rothstein & Goffin 2006).

At least implicit in any understanding of personality is consideration of the situations in which personality plays out. Whenever people think, feel, and behave, they do so in reaction to salient features of their environment. Individuation and prediction, accordingly, are best framed in context: We identify people as distinct when we see them react differently to the same cues (one person avoids danger while another approaches it; one eagerly takes up an invitation to socialize while another turns it down), and our prediction of an individual's behavior depends on the similarity of past and future cues. Figures are visible only against a background—so too with personality and situations.

## TRAIT ACTIVATION THEORY: MAIN FEATURES

### Situation Trait Relevance

Building on early interactionist thinking (e.g., Allport 1951, Lewin 1936, Murray 1938), TAT considers personality traits as latent potentials to behave (think, feel<sup>1</sup>) in identifiable ways (i.e., as indicative of one trait versus another) in response to trait-relevant situational cues. As with tools on a tool belt, traits are engaged when called on by the right type of situation. Someone high in sociability behaves sociably only when other people are available with whom to engage. In TAT terms, this triggering feature of situations is situation trait relevance.<sup>2</sup> A situation is relevant to a trait to the degree it offers opportunity for that trait to be expressed. Trait-relevant situations often have a main effect on behavior (e.g., socially engaging situations tend to increase sociable behavior in everyone present). Equally importantly, however, they expose individual differences on relevant traits: Social gatherings, better than any other type of situation, reveal who is and is not sociable.

Trait relevance is a key situational feature that makes a trait observable as an individual difference variable. Thus, when examining a given trait and its relationships with targeted outcomes, it is important to do so in trait-relevant situations. TAT builds on this fundamental principle in several key respects.

### Functional Situational Features

Unique to TAT is its articulation of six types of trait-relevant situational features, distinguished by how they moderate trait–outcome relationships. Tett & Burnett (2003) identified the first five; Tett et al. (2013) identified the sixth.

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<sup>1</sup>Trait expressions can include thoughts, feelings, and overt behaviors. We focus primarily on the latter because they are directly observable, permitting translation into work performance rated by others.

<sup>2</sup>Murray (1938) referred to this as press; Haaland & Christiansen (2002) call it trait activation potential, when operating in weak situations.

Demands are cues, responses to which are positively valued: Meeting a demand is a good thing. Conversely, distracters are cues, responses to which are valued negatively. An informal gathering of coworkers might distract those high on sociability from completing their assigned tasks. Both demands and distracters are trait activators; responses to a demand yield a positive relationship between the activated trait and a positively valued outcome, whereas responses to a distracter yield a negative relationship.<sup>3</sup>

Constraints are situational features rendering a given trait less relevant, thereby weakening the trait–outcome relationship. Physical distance separating a manager from subordinates constrains the relevance of sociability as a predictor of performance. Releasers counter constraints, operating as intermittent trait activators. For a physically isolated manager, a company retreat in Las Vegas might serve as a releaser of sociability, allowing it to correlate with relevant outcomes. A facilitator is uniquely multiplicative in that it enhances the salience or potency of trait-relevant cues already present. An ad extolling the playful opportunities in Las Vegas would amplify the sociability cues afforded by the retreat.

Discretionary cues account for trait effects untethered to valued outcomes. They are related to the general factor of work autonomy, which itself is tied to (low) situation strength. Discretionary cues are distinct from work autonomy (and weak situations) by their alignment to specific traits. A production supervisor position may not require creativity for effective performance but might nonetheless offer opportunity for creative expression (e.g., in developing training games). A sales job might offer cues for altruism (e.g., to assist peers) despite altruism not being expected, rewarded, or punished in any way. The key here is motivation: The creative supervisor and the altruistic salesperson will be more engaged in meeting their respective work demands when their jobs offer opportunity to engage those discretionary traits. Such cues are not definitive of the job, yet they offer unique contributions to trait-based fit (Tett et al. 2013).

### Operational Levels

In the workplace, the primary situational features affecting trait expression are task-level features, including all the day-to-day demands identified in a job description (e.g., budget preparation, forklift operation) and less overt demands (e.g., prompt attendance, rule-following), distracters, constraints, etc. Social-level (alternatively, group-level or team-level) features include the behaviors of peers, subordinates, and superiors, as well as norms and team culture/climate. Organization-level features operate within organizational culture and climate (e.g., policies, reward systems). Notably, the levels overlap. Management, leadership, and customer service jobs, for example, include task-level social demands. Team-based organizational cultures are similarly boundary spanning. Despite the overlaps, the three levels are well recognized in other workplace literatures [e.g., person–environment (PE) fit (Kristof-Brown & Guay 2010)]. Personality applications in the workplace often target task-level effects in the context of personnel selection, where meeting job-specific task demands is the primary predictive aim. Social- and organization-level demands are increasingly targeted in personality research, expanding bases for improving personality-based fit in the workplace.

### Trait Expression as (Valued) Performance

In addressing the noted bidirectionality of personality–performance relationships, TAT proposes that positive and negative correlations involving a given trait are distinguished by the value of the

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<sup>3</sup>Where the outcome is negatively valued [e.g., counterproductive work behaviors (CWBs)], a distracter yields a positive relationship.

resulting trait expression. Meta-analyses (e.g., Barrick & Mount 1991, Hough et al. 1998) have shown, for example, that agreeableness is positively related to performance in some managerial jobs and negatively related in other managerial jobs.<sup>4</sup> Agreeableness may be activated by similar trait-relevant cues; what varies is whether meeting demands is facilitated or hindered by managers' expressed agreeableness. The behavior/performance distinction thus separates the processes of trait activation and performance judgment. Observers (e.g., supervisors, peers) are active players in trait–performance linkages, converting behavioral observations into performance evaluations in light of how well a given behavior meets work demands. Accordingly, demands are both key trait activators and reference points for performance judgment.

## Motivation

TAT articulates four sources of trait-based work motivation. (a) Trait expression is intrinsically motivating as need satisfaction, akin to how drinking satiates thirst (Murray 1938). Extroverts seek out and respond to sociability cues because they derive pleasure from engaging others (Smillie 2013). (b) Knowledge of performance results is motivating to the degree the worker is achievement oriented: Performance feedback informs level of actual achievement, which is particularly salient to those higher on achievement need. (c) Per behaviorist reinforcement principles, trait expressions judged by others (e.g., as job performance) confer extrinsically motivating outcomes: salary, praise, etc., for positive evaluations; demotion, shunning, etc., for negative evaluations. (d) Extrinsic motivation is elevated in workers whose traits are aligned with valued outcomes (i.e., differential reward preference). The chance to be employee of the month, for example, may be especially motivating to an extrovert and shunning to a worker high on need for approval.

## TRAIT ACTIVATION THEORY APPLICATIONS

TAT offers an integrated framework for investigating critical issues involving personality at work. The model was developed explicitly to account for the following applications.

Proximate applications:

1. Explicitly proposed to account for variability in personality–job performance relationships across situations (i.e., situational specificity), TAT promotes situation trait relevance as a general moderating principle (Tett & Burnett 2003; Tett et al. 1991, 1994, 1999).
2. Bidirectionality occurs when a given trait is positively or negatively related to job performance depending on the work setting (Tett & Burnett 2003; Tett et al. 1991, 1994, 1999). Although often ignored, this special case of situational specificity is a critical consideration in meta-analyses of trait–outcome relations, as averaging positive and negative population estimates can grossly underestimate validity strength and hence the predictive value of personality (Tett et al. 1999, Tett & Christiansen 2007).
3. Cross-situational consistency in behavior, an elusive hallmark of stable traits, is understood in TAT to be a function of similarity in situation trait relevance (Tett & Guterman 2000).
4. Work autonomy is represented in TAT in terms of trait-specific discretionary cues (Tett et al. 2013), offering a unique basis for trait-based motivation independent of extrinsic outcomes.

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<sup>4</sup>Meta-analyses showing this do not identify which managerial jobs yield positive versus negative correlations; the evidence derives from 80% credibility intervals extending in both directions. Such intervals, with weak mean correlations, are common for agreeableness in management (see Tett & Christiansen 2007).

5. Dynamic interaction denotes reciprocal causation between traits and situations (Magnusson & Endler 1977, Weiss & Adler 1984). TAT proposes corresponding mechanisms by which trait expressions (as behavior) can (a) increase trait-relevant situational cues (positive feedback loop) or (b) decrease them (negative feedback loop).

#### Intermediate applications:

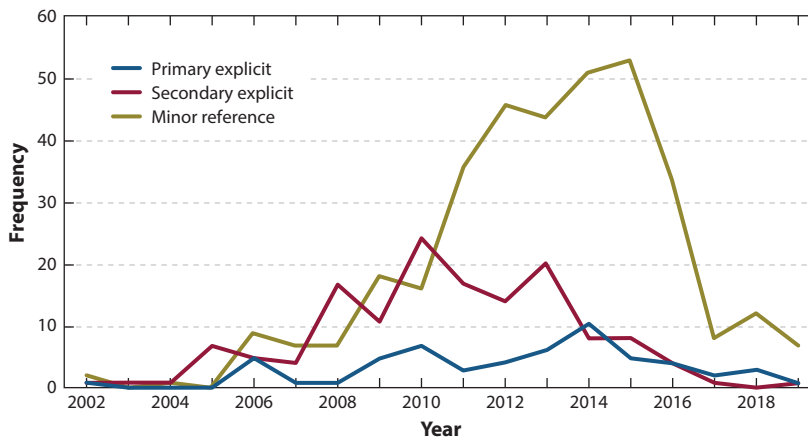
6. Offering a trait-based approach to person–workplace fit, TAT holds that people are happier and perform best in jobs, groups, and organizations where they are intrinsically and extrinsically rewarded for being themselves. By the same token, organizations prefer and are more successful with workers whose traits are motivating by their alignment with extant work demands and reward contingencies (Tett et al. 2013).
7. Personality-oriented work analysis is a natural extension of TAT: Trait-based personnel selection should be enhanced by targeting identification of situational features (e.g., demands, distracters) operating at multiple levels (task, group, organization) relevant to particular traits and rewards (O'Neill et al. 2013).
8. Situational taxonomies, frequently invited but rarely delivered (Rauthmann et al. 2014), are derivable with TAT by identifying classes of similarly trait-relevant situations (e.g., Ho & Gupta 2012, Parrigon et al. 2017).
9. Construct specificity offers key predictive advantages (e.g., Kholin et al. 2016, Rojon et al. 2015, Rothstein & Goffin 2006). TAT holds that trait-based predictions of work outcomes should improve with greater trait and criterion specificity because it feeds confirmatory precision in trait–situation linkages.

#### Distal applications:

10. TAT offers an interactionist basis for team-building: Teams should be more viable when members have what it takes not only to meet team task and role demands, but also to bring out the best work in one another via mutual trait activation [i.e., chemistry (Tett & Murphy 2002)].
11. Traits have been shown to play out in complex trait-by-trait interactions (e.g., Witt 2002, Witt et al. 2004). TAT can frame those effects in light of trait-relevant situational complexities.
12. TAT offers a unique approach to understanding halo bias in performance appraisal: Person A will rate person B positively on diverse dimensions to the degree B provides A the opportunity to express traits in positively valued ways (intrinsically and extrinsically), potentially overpowering evaluation of B's true performance and differential assessment on distinct performance dimensions.
13. Although centered on personality traits, TAT readily extends to activation of knowledge, skills, and abilities (KSAs),<sup>5</sup> with the key distinction that only personality traits carry intrinsic motivational force as need satisfaction (Tett et al. 2013).
14. Finally, TAT can augment and expand application of other theories, including social-cognitive mechanisms involving dispositions (e.g., conscientiousness, impulsivity), social exchange principles (e.g., LMX theory), as well as personality states, self-regulation (SR), and other processes in the context of dynamic person–situation systems.

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<sup>5</sup>Even general cognitive ability shows situational specificity as a function of job complexity (Hunter et al. 1990).



**Figure 1**

Frequencies of primary, secondary, and tertiary sources citing key trait activation theory sources by year since 2002.

## SUMMARY OF THE TRAIT ACTIVATION THEORY LITERATURE (2011–2019)

As with Tett et al.'s (2013) review, sources for the current review were identified by tracking citations of Tett & Guterman (2000) and Tett & Burnett (2003) in the PsycInfo database. We also tracked citations of Tett et al. (2013). Sources were mined independently by the three authors, targeting TAT's features and applications presented above. We also tracked whether or not TAT is cited in direct reference to the given issue in clarifying reliance on TAT within sources citing it.<sup>6</sup> Ambiguous cases in all aspects of the mining were resolved by consensus.

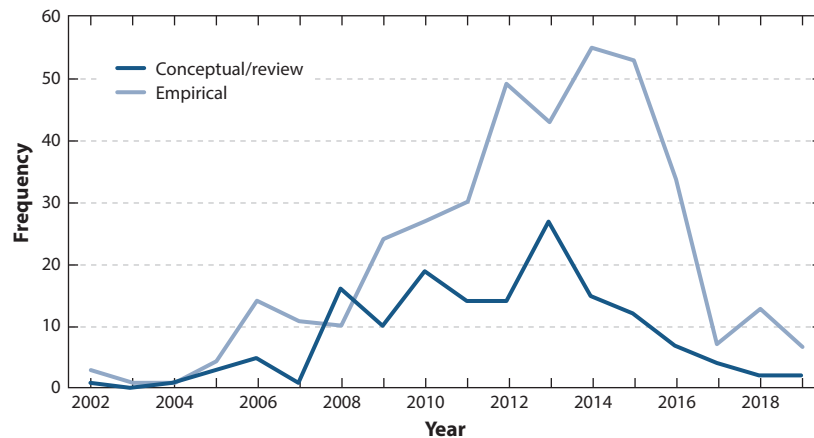
The earlier search, covering 2002–2011, yielded 189 published sources citing the introductory articles. Of the 184 available sources, 23 (13%) targeted TAT as a main focus and another 88 (48%), as a secondary but explicit focus. Corresponding counts for the current search period are 389 in total,<sup>7</sup> 34 (9%) targeting TAT as a main focus and 65 (16%) as a secondary but explicit focus. **Figure 1** tracks the frequencies of primary, secondary, and tertiary sources by year since 2002. Empirical sources outpaced conceptual sources in the earlier review by 121 (66%) to 63 (34%), compared to 293 (75%) versus 90 (25%) in the current review. **Figure 2** shows corresponding frequencies by year.

This birds-eye view suggests (a) the 2:1 ratio of empirical to conceptual applications evident up to 2011 (i.e., 66:34) has shifted to a 3:1 ratio more recently (i.e., 75:25); (b) the 12/48/40 proportional split in primary/secondary/tertiary citations evident up to 2011 has become a 9/16/75 split, showing a relative drop in primary and especially secondary applications offset by an increase in tertiary, mostly empirical applications; and (c) TAT citations continued an upward trajectory from the first review until 2015, at which point the trend reversed.<sup>8</sup> As in the 2013 review, only those sources relying primarily and secondarily on TAT are summarized in detail here.

<sup>6</sup>Sources citing TAT directly for some issues often address other relevant issues independently of TAT.

<sup>7</sup>PsycInfo captures a subset of sources citing the noted articles. An April 2020 search in Google Scholar, for example, yielded more than 1,600 citations of Tett & Burnett (2003) for the same review period. Reliance on PsycInfo provided a manageable number of peer-reviewed sources and comparability to the earlier review.

<sup>8</sup>Google Scholar does not show a corresponding drop. The reason for the discrepancy is unclear.



**Figure 2**

Frequency of source type by year since 2002.

### Situation Trait Relevance and Situational Specificity

Sources citing TAT with respect to situational specificity of personality–outcome relations do so in terms of situation trait relevance. Accordingly, those concepts are combined here. Of the 99 primary or secondary sources, 90<sup>9</sup> targeted situational specificity, 84 with direct ties to TAT. The high rate of reliance on TAT for this purpose is not surprising, given the theory’s emphasis on situation trait relevance. Most cases involve FFM linkages with performance in particular jobs. Others extend to job stages (Woods et al. 2013), assessment centers (ACs) (e.g., Melchers et al. 2012), team settings (e.g., Heidemeier & Bittner 2012), virtual versus real-life settings (McLeod et al. 2014), and nonwork settings (e.g., De Fruyt & De Clercq 2014) as well as to relations involving nonperformance outcomes, such as values and work attitudes (e.g., Bergman et al. 2013), motivation (e.g., Woods et al. 2013), and affect (e.g., Dimotakis et al. 2012). Such breadth of application supports the generalizability of situation relevance as a key variable in understanding person–outcome linkages.

### Functional Situational Features

Of the 99 reviewed sources, 49 identified situational features related to trait expression (e.g., demands, distracters), 42 making specific reference to TAT. Debusscher et al. (2016), for example, examined work pressure and task complexity as distracters for state neuroticism in predicting momentary task performance. Bouckennooghe et al. (2013) examined job satisfaction<sup>10</sup> as a facilitator of positive affectivity relating to job performance and turnover intentions. Other studies invoked situational features consistent with the TAT taxonomy but without explicitly identifying it. For example, Chen et al. (2013) presented rule-oriented organizational culture as a mitigator of negative affect expression as CWB, the culture operating as a TAT constraint on negative affect.

<sup>9</sup>Percentages of the 99 reviewed sources are omitted because they are virtually identical to the raw frequencies.

<sup>10</sup>According to the researchers, more satisfied workers attend more closely to situational cues, thereby amplifying their effects. TAT, as originally proposed, does not specify psychological moderators. Below, we document this and other extensions of TAT separately.



The 2013 review revealed reference to distinct situational features in 8% of sources. The rise to 50% in the current effort reflects increasing recognition of the variety of ways situations can affect trait expression and trait–outcome linkages. No moderator effects were observed outside the TAT taxonomy, suggesting the framework is comprehensive in organizing interactions by functional type.

### **Operational Levels**

Of the 74 empirical articles, 44 (59%) applied TAT at the task level, 28 (38%) at the social level, and 10 (14%) at the organization level. Across all 99 reviewed sources, 40 explicitly discussed interactions as operating at one or more levels, 35 with direct reference to TAT. Fourteen targeted two or more levels, mostly combining task and social levels. Schmidt et al. (2012), for example, examined the influence of team-level dissimilarity in extraversion and conscientiousness on task-level FFM relations with individual performance and CWBs. These studies underscore the importance of understanding the multi-level influence of trait expression. Choi et al. (2015) and De Fruyt & Wille (2013) extended trait activation to national culture, adding a fourth level.

### **Separation of Behavior and Performance**

Twenty sources explicitly or implicitly distinguished performance as valued behavior, four drawing directly from TAT. Blickle et al. (2013), for example, articulate the trait expression/performance distinction in showing conscientiousness predicts task performance when professional roles trigger both learning orientation and political skill. Ten sources make the distinction implicitly, most in the context of bidirectionality. Most sources ignore the behavior/performance distinction, attributing value to the trait itself. Linking conscientiousness to detailed task performance does not require separate evaluation of conscientious behavior. Trait evaluation is a convenient heuristic for the trait–behavior–performance chain. Studies of bidirectionality and the active role of performance judges invite clearer separation under TAT.

### **Bidirectionality**

Thirteen papers discussed moderation of the direction of predictor–outcomes linkages, eight tying such effects directly to TAT. Simonet et al. (2017), for example, reported bidirectional effects of dark-side traits as a function of managerial level: Reactive narcissists performing poorly as “loose cannons” at lower levels may be effective as “tough talkers” at upper levels (p. 245). All but one case of bidirectionality was reported between work settings. Xu et al. (2014) discuss bidirectionality in leadership in the context of dynamic personality processes. Evidence for bidirectionality, whether between or within jobs, underscores concerns that meta-analyses ignoring it (e.g., Barrick & Mount 1991, Hertz & Donovan 2000) underestimate the predictive power of personality due to cancellation of positive and negative effects (Tett et al. 1991, 1994, 1999, Tett & Christiansen 2007).

### **Trait-Based Motivation**

Intrinsic motivation from trait expression was discussed in 19 sources, 15 with direct ties to TAT. For example, Hirst et al. (2011) argued people high on learning goal orientation are intrinsically motivated to face new challenges, especially when unimpeded by bureaucracy. Fifteen sources cited TAT explicitly with respect to extrinsic motivation. Van Hove & Turban (2015), for instance, hypothesized applicants are attracted to organizations rewarding traits they possess. Extrinsic rewards can also restrict trait effects. For example, Liguori et al. (2013) suggested conscientiousness

predicts organizational citizenship behaviors (OCBs) only where rewards are weak. No source targeted differential reward preference (Tett et al. 2013), whereby traits affect the motivational force of different outcomes. This remains a mostly open question from a TAT perspective.

### **Cross-Situational Consistency**

Four sources cited cross-situational consistency. Christiansen et al. (2013), for example, describe how TAT can be used to address this in ACs, (see also Lievens et al. 2006) and Campion & Ployhart (2013) make a similar point with respect to situational judgment tests (SJTs). TAT may help address long-standing concerns regarding construct validity in ACs by holding that consistency across exercises (e.g., in-basket, leaderless group discussion) occurs only to the degree those methods activate the same traits with similar value (e.g., Haaland & Christiansen 2002, Lievens et al. 2015). Applications of TAT to modeling behavioral consistency in other multi-situation assessments await empirical investigation.

### **Situation Strength and Autonomy**

Situation strength was noted in 46 of the reviewed sources, making it the third most commonly raised issue, behind only situation trait relevance (90) and functional cue types (50). In 32 cases, strength was linked closely to TAT, mostly hand-in-hand with situation trait-relevance effects. Fulmer & Walker (2015), for example, found extroverted and less conscientious workers performed better under a piece-rate reward contingency in a weaker, unstructured task but not a stronger, structured task. Judge & Zapata (2015) meta-analytically compared situation trait relevance and situation strength as moderators of personality–performance linkages. Such direct comparisons are not surprising, given both factors have been identified as important in understanding trait–situation interactions.

### **Dynamic Interaction**

Six sources discuss behavioral effects of traits on situations, in three cases as part of the targeted trait. Proactive personality, for example, entails efforts to modify one's environment (e.g., Li et al. 2011). Two sources tie dynamic interaction directly to TAT. Sung et al. (2014), for example, do so in terms of mutual trait activation (Tett & Murphy 2002). This process can be understood as involving positive and negative feedback loops (Tett & Burnett 2003) as particular forms of dynamic interaction; otherwise, such mechanisms have not received attention to date. Judge & Zapata (2015) identify trait effects on situations as targets for future meta-analytic research.

### **Person–Workplace Fit**

Seventeen sources discussed person–workplace fit in terms of traits, eight specifically in TAT terms. As evident in the fit literature generally, fit was considered most often at the organizational level and secondarily at the social (team, group) level. Klehe et al. (2014), for example, discuss the evaluative implications of fit between individuals, teams, and organizations, and Dimotakis et al. (2012) found that negotiators high versus low on agreeableness were a better fit in integrative versus distributive exchanges, respectively. Notably, TAT integrates fit between the individual and their job, supervisor, team, and organization. Further insights into TAT's role in person–workplace fit are offered by Tett et al. (2013) and at the end of this article.

## Personality-Oriented Work Analysis

Two sources suggested application of TAT to personality-oriented work analysis (O'Neill et al. 2013, generally, and Simonet et al. 2017, more specifically) to identify conditions affecting the expression and impact of dark personality traits in work settings. Despite the availability of relevant instruments (e.g., Raymark et al. 1997), researchers continue to rely on traditional work analysis, job descriptions, ONET, and, in many cases, job titles in identifying locally relevant traits. This seems a missed opportunity to capitalize on the advantages of trait-specific analyses as a refined confirmatory strategy (Aguinis et al. 2009; Goffin et al. 2011; O'Neill et al. 2013; Tett et al. 1991, 1994, 1999).

## Situational Taxonomies

TAT was cited with respect to situational taxonomies in two sources. In their meta-analysis of situation trait relevance and situation strength effects, Judge & Zapata (2015) identified several prominent situational factors based on TAT (e.g., attention to detail, independence), although the list is far from complete. Connelly et al. (2017) suggested situational taxonomies would promote trait–situation interactionist research. Such efforts are consistent with Tett & Burnett's (2003) suggestion that situation trait relevance offers a promising basis for organizing diverse situational factors in ways directly germane to trait–situation interactions (see Parrigon et al. 2017).

## Trait Specificity

Twelve sources considered trait specificity in trait–situation interactions, four with direct reference to TAT. Greenbaum et al. (2017), for example, found Machiavellianism facets (e.g., amoral manipulation, desire for control) are differentially activated by abusive supervision in predicting unethical conduct and, more specifically, social undermining. The major theme in all such sources is that, consistent with prior reviews (e.g., Rojon et al. 2015, Rothstein & Goffin 2006), trait–outcome linkages are stronger and more interpretable when based on narrow trait and criterion pairings. Reliance on TAT for this purpose supports its use for advancing confirmatory strategies.

## Team Building

Only two sources addressed issues relating to team building. Sung et al. (2014) used TAT to assess how asymmetric dissimilarities in group members' personality traits affect OCB and task performance and how such effects vary over time. Hirst et al. (2011) urge organizations to exclude avoidance-oriented workers from creative teams and to decentralize and deformalize team settings, allowing learning-oriented and prove-oriented team members to flourish. Teams are composed of multiple, typically interdependent members, each with their own personality traits and KSAs varying in relevance to team tasks, roles, and norms. Accordingly, teamwork seems especially rich in opportunities for trait–situation interactions. Whether TAT or some other interactionist model might help frame such complexities remains largely unexplored (see Driskell & Salas 2013).

## Complex Interactions

Seventeen sources considered interactions among multiple traits, eight relying closely on TAT in modeling situational moderation. Schmidt et al. (2012), for example, found conscientiousness predicts performance positively and CWBs negatively in groups with high core-group evaluations and/or mean conscientiousness, whereas extraversion predicts CWBs positively in groups with high mean extraversion. Simonet et al. (2017) report the interactive combination of narcissism

and adjustment facets of dark-side personality is negatively linked to leader performance only in lower-level positions.

### Performance Appraisal

Two sources used TAT to investigate the performance appraisal process. Harari et al. (2015) meta-analyzed relations between evaluators' FFM traits and performance ratings under various conditions (e.g., field versus lab settings). Agreeableness proved the strongest predictor (mean  $\rho = 0.25$  overall, 0.33 in field settings). Such efforts are beginning to explore the performance appraisal process from an interactionist standpoint, but much remains unknown in this area. Halo bias seems a particularly worthwhile target for TAT (Tett & Burnett 2003) as a function of mutual trait activation between raters and ratees.

### Knowledge, Skills, and Abilities Activation

Seven sources cited TAT in support of KSA activation. For example, knowledge sharing was activated by coworker support (Lee et al. 2015) and extrinsic reward perceptions (Wang et al. 2012). Farh et al. (2012) identified emotional displays in emotional labor situations as activators of emotion perception skill. Extension of TAT to activation of KSAs and other variables (e.g., motives, values) supports the generalizability of situation relevance beyond its application to mainstream personality domains.

### Complementary Theories

Of the 99 reviewed sources, 35 combined TAT with a total of 26 other theories in framing empirical hypotheses and/or conceptual models. The three theories most commonly paired with TAT (each in four studies) were those of leader-member exchange (LMX), social exchange theory (SET), and PE fit. LMX theory (e.g., Dansereau et al. 1975) holds that leaders prefer followers offering more favorable inputs (e.g., skills, motivation) to the exchange process. Runhaar et al. (2013) used TAT to show how high LMX relationships constrain cues for work engagement expressed as organizational citizenship behavior at the organizational level. As a foundation for LMX theory, SET (e.g., Blau 1964, Gouldner 1960) holds that individuals engage others when the benefits exceed the costs and reciprocate when receiving desirable exchanges (e.g., norm of reciprocity). Haynie (2012) showed that exchange ideology (i.e., team-member exchange) activates core self-evaluations in predicting team performance.

That the two theories most commonly paired with TAT focus on interpersonal exchanges invites more formal integration along those lines. A possible link is mutual trait activation (Sung et al. 2014, Tett & Murphy 2002), whereby one person's trait expressions activate another's traits. Compatibility is expected when exchange partners bring out the best in one another and avoid pushing one another's buttons. The key units of exchange in this process are trait-based need satisfaction, driving intrinsic motivation, and valued outcomes, driving extrinsic motivation. A TAT rendering of LMX theory along those lines seems especially opportune.

PE fit theory (e.g., Kristof 1996, Kristof-Brown & Guay 2010) holds that workers are matched to their work situations to the degree their skills and abilities meet work demands (demands-abilities fit) and the organization meets the worker's needs (needs-supplies fit). Bergman et al. (2013) combined TAT with PE fit theory in proposing fit-driven organizational commitment derives from activation of workers' values by relevant work events. As noted by Tett et al. (2013), personality traits, unlike KSAs and values, contribute to fit via both needs-supplies and trait-demands mechanisms, making them uniquely important constructs in PE fit.

Theories paired with TAT in two sources include Locke & Latham's (1990) goal-setting theory, Mischel & Shoda's (1995) cognitive-affective personality system, Holland's (1997) vocational theory, Kelley & Thibaut's (1978) interdependence theory, Deci & Ryan's (2008) self-determination theory, and Bass's (1985) transformational leadership theory.

The noted 35% of reviewed sources pairing TAT with companion theories is a marked increase over the corresponding 7% of papers Tett et al. (2013) identified. This jump in theoretical complementarity supports the flexibility of TAT as an integrative framework.

### **Trait Activation Theory Extensions**

Several sources proposed construct- or process-focused TAT extensions. Regarding constructs, several studies considered the situational relevance of predictors and criteria beyond the usual personality and performance domains. Jung & Takeuchi (2014), for example, assessed LMX moderation effects on relations between person-organization fit and work attitudes. Similarly, Neal et al. (2012) considered differential trait activation effects on distinct performance facets (e.g., task proficiency versus adaptivity). Two studies examined situational moderators operating at the level of national culture (Choi et al. 2015, Holtschlag et al. 2013), above the three levels originally proposed. Other studies examined psychological moderators, extending TAT principles beyond strictly situational moderation. Oh et al. (2014), for example, describe how self-monitoring suppresses (i.e., constrains) expression of low agreeableness as individual-level counterproductive work behavior.<sup>11</sup> This type of effect is distinct from moderation by perceived situational factors (e.g., judged LMX quality), which are psychologically mediated.

Expanding on TAT processes, a few sources (e.g., Bipp & Klienbeck 2011, Debusscher et al. 2016) advance states as short-term mediators of trait effects. Harris et al. (2016) add implicit trait policies and job knowledge as moderators of situational effects on trait-performance linkages in SJTs, further conditioning trait-outcome relationships. Building on the behavior/performance distinction, Lievens et al. (2015) merge TAT with Funder's (2012) realistic accuracy model in showing AC construct validation requires recognition of elicited traits. Woods et al. (2013) summarize findings suggesting habitual trait activation (over years) causes shifts in population trait means, such that behavior affects trait standing. Similarly, Xu et al. (2014) offer case studies of how leader traits "evolve" by experience throughout life (e.g., mischievousness in childhood becomes spirituality in later adulthood).

The noted expansions of TAT promote insight into how personality and related variables play out in work settings as a function of situational and extended moderation. None challenges TAT in any fundamental respect, and further research will determine their theoretical efficacy.

### **Personality Dynamics**

Eight sources addressed personality-situation interactions in the context of dynamic personality systems, six with explicit ties to TAT. Xu et al. (2014), for example, rely on TAT in advancing a dynamic, "evolutionary" process of leader personality change, whereby "intrinsic" traits vary in intensity and "extrinsic" traits are replaced based on the leader's exposure to key situations and events throughout the lifetime. Several papers apply TAT to personality states (e.g., Heidemeier & Bittner 2012). More detailed analysis of how TAT might advance the study of personality dynamics is offered in the second half of the current article, following review of empirical tests of TAT-inspired moderation effects in work settings.

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<sup>11</sup> Such effects might be configured as trait-by-trait interactions. Classification by moderator type (constraint in this case) captures the researcher's portrayal in TAT terms.

## SUMMARY OF EMPIRICALLY TESTED TRAIT ACTIVATION THEORY MODERATOR EFFECTS

Of the 75 empirical articles explicitly grounded in TAT over the current review period, 60 (80%) reported a total of 262 moderator effects. Results bear consideration in terms of (a) test frequencies, showing how TAT has been applied in assessing moderators, and (b) percentages of those tests that are statistically significant, showing where TAT has been successful. Regarding TAT applications, **Table 1** presents test frequency percentages and corresponding interpretations for predictor categories (e.g., FFM traits), functional cues (i.e., moderator types), and operational levels. Overall, TAT has been applied (a) at all three proposed levels and further to the broader cultural level; (b) in terms of all six moderator types (most often demands, rarely releasers), and (c) to a broad variety of predictors, including not only mainstream FFM traits but also KSAs and other variables outside the core personality domain.

Speaking to the success of TAT moderation effects, **Table 2** presents test frequencies and percentages significant per predictor category and functional cue, crossed with operational level.<sup>12</sup> Frequencies for moderator types other than demands were too small in many cells to permit meaningful interpretations. Accordingly, frequencies are provided per operational level for (a) demands only (distracters in the case of neuroticism), (b) predictor categories collapsing across moderator types, and (c) moderator types collapsing across predictor categories. Results are notable in several respects.

First, the overall 60% significance rate is far above the nominal 5% Type I error rate, in support of TAT-driven moderation of predictor–outcome linkages. Second, significance rates vary across predictor categories ( $p < 0.05$ ), ranging from 40% for compounds to 79% for emotional stability/neuroticism. Corresponding rates based only on demands are similarly variable, ranging from 38% for compounds to 93% for emotional stability/neuroticism. At the task level, significance rates are relatively high for openness: 74% collapsing across moderator types and 81% based on demand effects alone. These results suggest emotional stability/neuroticism and openness may be particularly sensitive to situational moderation. The most relevant moderator of emotional stability/neuroticism relations is work stress. Stressors may be an especially salient and potent trait activator. Demands for creativity may be similarly evocative of openness. Among the strongest moderator effects in Judge & Zapata's (2015) meta-analysis was that of demand for innovation on openness–performance linkages. Differential range restriction and situation strength across predictor classes is another possibility. Further study is needed to compare situational moderators regarding their trait activation potential (Haaland & Christiansen 2002).

Third, significance rates are similar across operational levels ( $p > 0.50$ ), ranging from 53% to 65%, in support of the multi-level structure of TAT and its noted expansion to national culture (Choi et al. 2015, Holtschlag et al. 2013). Fourth, collapsing across operational levels and omitting the two releaser cases, significance rates are similar across moderator types ( $p > 0.20$ ). Thus, no moderator type is more effective overall. However, for the 154 nonreleaser cases at the task level (60% of all cases), significance rates do vary across moderator types ( $p < 0.05$ ), ranging from 45% for discretionary cues to 100% for distracters. As discretionary cues represent (trait-specific) weak

<sup>12</sup>All significant cases reported here are in the direction predicted by the researchers. Few, if any, of these hypothesized effects were assessed using one-tailed tests. Accordingly, reported hit rates may underestimate moderation effects. Other factors to consider are the relatively low power of moderation tests (Aguinis et al. 2017) and possible inflation of significance rates due to publication bias. The latter factor may be counteracting the first two to some degree.

**Table 1** How has trait activation theory (TAT) been applied? Percentages of empirical tests of TAT moderator effects per predictor category, moderator feature, and operational level in 60 empirical studies (2011–2019)

| Targeted predictors and TAT features | % of tests               | Interpretation                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|--------------------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Predictors                           |                          |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Conscientiousness                    | 16%                      | The distribution of tested effects across the FFM dimensions is fairly even (10–16%); not surprisingly, conscientiousness was the most commonly targeted attribute. Frequent targeting of KSAs and motivational variables (21% combined) suggests situation relevance generalizes beyond application to personality traits alone.                                                                                                    |
| Agreeableness                        | 11%                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Extraversion/PA                      | 12%                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Neuroticism/NA/emotional stability   | 10%                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Openness                             | 11%                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Compounds                            | 6%                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Miscellaneous personality            | 14%                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| KSAs                                 | 6%                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Motivation                           | 15%                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Functional cue types                 |                          |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Demands                              | 60%                      | The commonality of demands reflects their close connection to performance. Combining demands and distracters yields a large majority (71%), consistent with TAT's primary focus on trait activators. Discretionary cues account for 13% of task-level cases, suggesting notable reliance on TAT in modeling trait-specific work autonomy. Releasers are rarely assessed, understandably given their definition as temporary factors. |
| Distracters                          | 11%                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Constraints                          | 13%                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Releasers                            | 1%                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Facilitators                         | 8%                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Discretionary cues (autonomy)        | 8%                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Operational levels                   |                          |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Task                                 | 60%                      | Not surprisingly, most moderator effects were operationalized at the task level, followed by the social level. Organization-level moderators were relatively rare. Ten cases from two sources were assessed at the national culture level, expanding TAT application beyond the three levels originally described.                                                                                                                   |
| Social                               | 30%                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Organizational                       | 6%                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| National (new)                       | 4%                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Predictor by operational level       |                          |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Motivation                           | 28% (task), 59% (social) | Consistent with social–cognitive models emphasizing the social nature of work motivation (e.g., Farmer & Van Dyne 2010), motivational variables were the only predictor type more commonly targeted at the social level than the task level ( $\chi^2 = 20.63$ , $df = 1$ , $p < 0.0001$ ).                                                                                                                                          |
| Remaining predictors                 | 65% (task), 30% (social) |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Cue type by operational level        |                          |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Demands                              | 64% (task), 25% (social) | Test frequencies for the six moderator types vary proportionately between the task and social levels ( $\chi^2 = 38.42$ , $df = 4$ , $p < 0.0001$ ). Demands, facilitators, and discretionary cues (autonomy) were more commonly targeted at the task level. Distracters and constraints tended to be modeled more distally in the social context of work.                                                                           |
| Distracters                          | 38% (task), 52% (social) |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Constraints                          | 23% (task), 57% (social) |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Facilitators                         | 75% (task), 25% (social) |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Discretionary cues                   | 100% (task), 0% (social) |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |

Abbreviations: FFM, five-factor model; KSAs, knowledge, skills, and abilities; PA, positive affectivity; NA, negative affectivity.

situations, the lower hit rate for this moderator class supports Judge & Zapata's (2015) meta-analytic results favoring situation trait relevance over situation strength.

The main take-away is that the predictive and explanatory advantages of a given personality trait are conditional on conceptually relevant situational and psychological factors. The value of personality traits, accordingly, should be assessed under trait-relevant conditions and will be underestimated to the degree effects are undifferentiated on trait relevance (Tett & Christiansen



**Table 2** How successful is trait activation theory (TAT) as a moderator framework? Frequencies of empirical tests of TAT moderator effects and percent significant by predictor category and moderator feature per operational level in 60 empirical studies (2011–2019)<sup>a</sup>

| Predictor/situational feature                                    | Task level |              | Social level |              | Organizational level |              | Cultural level |              | Totals     |              |
|------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|--------------|--------------|--------------|----------------------|--------------|----------------|--------------|------------|--------------|
|                                                                  | <i>f</i>   | % sig.       | <i>f</i>     | % sig.       | <i>f</i>             | % sig.       | <i>f</i>       | % sig.       | <i>f</i>   | % sig.       |
| <b>Predictor categories collapsing across moderator features</b> |            |              |              |              |                      |              |                |              |            |              |
| Conscientiousness                                                | 29         | 34.5%        | 8            | 87.5%        | 3                    | 0.0%         | 2              | 100.0%       | 42         | 45.2%        |
| Agreeableness                                                    | 16         | 37.5%        | 10           | 80.0%        | 1                    | 100.0%       | 2              | 100.0%       | 29         | 58.6%        |
| Extraversion/PA                                                  | 20         | 65.0%        | 12           | 33.3%        | 0                    |              | 0              |              | 32         | 53.1%        |
| Neuroticism/NA                                                   | 10         | 90.0%        | 0            |              | 3                    | 66.7%        | 1              | 0.0%         | 14         | 78.6%        |
| Emotional stability                                              | 5          | 100.0%       | 5            | 80.0%        | 0                    |              | 1              | 0.0%         | 11         | 81.8%        |
| Openness                                                         | 23         | 73.9%        | 3            | 0.0%         | 3                    | 33.3%        | 0              |              | 29         | 58.6%        |
| Compounds                                                        | 11         | 45.5%        | 4            | 25.0%        | 0                    |              | 0              |              | 15         | 40.0%        |
| Miscellaneous personality                                        | 24         | 62.5%        | 12           | 58.3%        | 0                    |              | 0              |              | 36         | 61.1%        |
| KSAs                                                             | 7          | 42.9%        | 2            | 100.0%       | 2                    | 100.0%       | 4              | 50.0%        | 15         | 60.0%        |
| Motivation                                                       | 11         | 72.7%        | 23           | 78.3%        | 5                    | 80.0%        | 0              |              | 39         | 76.9%        |
| <b>Predictor categories: demands only<sup>b</sup></b>            |            |              |              |              |                      |              |                |              |            |              |
| Conscientiousness                                                | 20         | 35.0%        | 8            | 87.5%        | 3                    | 0.0%         | 2              | 100.0%       | 33         | 48.5%        |
| Agreeableness                                                    | 12         | 41.7%        | 7            | 85.7%        | 1                    | 100.0%       | 2              | 100.0%       | 22         | 63.6%        |
| Extraversion/PA                                                  | 13         | 61.5%        | 10           | 40.0%        | 0                    |              | 0              |              | 23         | 52.2%        |
| Neuroticism/NA <sup>b</sup>                                      | 5          | 100.0%       | 0            |              | 1                    | 100.0%       | 0              |              | 6          | 100.0%       |
| Emotional stability                                              | 5          | 100.0%       | 4            | 100.0%       | 0                    |              | 1              | 0.0%         | 10         | 90.0%        |
| Openness                                                         | 16         | 81.3%        | 1            | 0.0%         | 1                    | 0.0%         | 0              |              | 18         | 72.2%        |
| Compounds                                                        | 8          | 37.5%        | 0            |              | 0                    |              | 0              |              | 8          | 37.5%        |
| Miscellaneous personality                                        | 18         | 50.0%        | 2            | 0.0%         | 0                    |              | 0              |              | 20         | 45.0%        |
| KSAs                                                             | 7          | 42.9%        | 1            | 100.0%       | 2                    | 100.0%       | 2              | 50.0%        | 12         | 58.3%        |
| Motivation                                                       | 1          | 100.0%       | 6            | 83.3%        | 2                    | 100.0%       | 0              |              | 9          | 88.9%        |
| <b>Moderator features collapsing across predictor categories</b> |            |              |              |              |                      |              |                |              |            |              |
| Demand                                                           | 100        | 54.0%        | 39           | 69.2%        | 9                    | 55.6%        | 8              | 62.5%        | 156        | 58.3%        |
| Distracter                                                       | 11         | 100.0%       | 15           | 53.3%        | 3                    | 66.7%        | 0              |              | 29         | 72.4%        |
| Constraint                                                       | 8          | 62.5%        | 20           | 65.0%        | 5                    | 40.0%        | 2              | 50.0%        | 35         | 60.0%        |
| Releaser                                                         | 2          | 100.0%       | 0            |              | 0                    |              | 0              |              | 2          | 100.0%       |
| Facilitator                                                      | 15         | 66.7%        | 5            | 60.0%        | 0                    |              | 0              |              | 20         | 65.0%        |
| Discretionary cue                                                | 20         | 45.0%        | 0            |              | 0                    |              | 0              |              | 20         | 45.0%        |
| <b>Grand total</b>                                               | <b>156</b> | <b>58.3%</b> | <b>79</b>    | <b>64.6%</b> | <b>17</b>            | <b>52.9%</b> | <b>10</b>      | <b>60.0%</b> | <b>262</b> | <b>59.9%</b> |

Abbreviations: KSA, knowledge, skills, and abilities; NA, negative affectivity; PA, positive affectivity.

<sup>a</sup>All effects contributing to % sig. are in the predicted direction; 5.7% of the 262 total effects are significant in the opposite direction. % sig. likely underestimates true hit rates owing to reliance on two-tailed tests instead of one-tailed tests in most source studies.

<sup>b</sup>Neuroticism effects are for distracters; the only demand case for neuroticism was non-significant at the national culture level.

2007). Aggregating effects by broad job families and outcome classes (e.g., Barrick & Mount 1991, Hurtz & Donovan 2000) are steps in the right direction, but situation trait relevance further differentiates effects within those classes, affording greater precision in understanding how and why personality is linked to valued outcomes. The effects of any trait, including conscientiousness, can be differentially activated, constrained, released, and facilitated by situational factors operating at multiple levels and may be further subject to trait-specific discretionary cues. Having shown the



value of TAT in advancing the role of personality in work settings, we now consider how it might advance the study of personality dynamics.

## TRAIT ACTIVATION THEORY AND PERSONALITY DYNAMICS

Researchers are increasingly turning their attention to within-person variability in understanding personality as a dynamic system (Wille & De Fruyt 2014). Personality dynamics may be understood as “theory based, testable processes mediating changes in an individual’s thoughts, feelings, and behaviors in response to internal and external demands” (Tett & Fisher 2020). Focusing on change over time adds complexity to the study of personality, beyond that conferred by trait–situation interactions. Modeling such change is important in fully rendering personality effects in work settings as dynamic systems.

Tett & Fisher (2020) identify five distinct but interrelated research lines on personality dynamics at work: (a) dispositional change (e.g., self-monitoring), (b) person–situation interactions (i.e., situational specificity), (c) personality states, (d) personality and career development, and (e) self-regulation (SR) approaches to work motivation. They also identify five key issues framed by TAT relevant to within-person variability: (a) cross-situational consistency versus variability; (b) the behavior/performance distinction; (c) interpersonal compatibility as a function of mutual trait activation; (d) dynamic interaction, per positive and negative feedback loops; and (e) a need-based motivational system (i.e., primary intrinsic reward from trait expression, secondary intrinsic reward from knowledge of performance results, and differential preference for extrinsic rewards). Below, each research stream is considered in light of each TAT issue as a  $5 \times 5$  matrix, summarized in **Table 3**.<sup>13</sup> Mapping personality dynamics domains to TAT issues offers both an integration of diverse lines of inquiry within a parsimonious theoretical framework and identification of promising lines of research.

### Trait Activation Theory and Dispositional Change

Tett & Fisher (2020) offer three examples of change-related dispositions. Neuroticism entails volatility in negative emotions and reactivity to threats; adaptability entails modifying one’s behavior and maintaining composure in meeting variable, stressful demands; and self-monitoring entails deliberate manipulation of one’s observable behavior in interpersonal encounters. Other intrapersonal, change-related traits include functional flexibility (Lievens et al. 2018) and adventurousness. Traits targeting changes to one’s environment include charisma (changing others) and proactive personality (changing work situations). Below, we detail how TAT might help advance personality dynamics involving change-related traits.

TAT holds that behavior is consistent across situations only to the degree those situations are similarly trait relevant (Haaland & Christiansen 2002, Tett & Guterman 2000). Change-related dispositions should, accordingly, be evident over multiple change-related situations: Someone who repeatedly modifies their actions to meet changing demands will be identified as adaptable or flexible; one who routinely accommodates the interaction styles of diverse others will be seen as high on self-monitoring. Because change is the target of observation, variable surface behaviors must be distinguished from deeper dispositional consistencies (Dalal et al. 2020, Mischel & Shoda 1995). Personality dynamics deals with more than surface-level variability; however, where characteristic patterns of change are evident across similar situations, surface-level variability marks underlying consistency in dispositional change.

<sup>13</sup> Although Tett & Fisher (2020) set out both the five lines of personality dynamics research and the five TAT issues, they did not discuss their intersection as offered here.

Table 3 Advancing personality dynamics through trait activation theory (TAT): applying five TAT topics (columns) to five personality dynamics subdomains (rows)

| Personality dynamics subdomain                         | CSC versus CSV                                                          | Behavior/performance distinction                                                   | Interpersonal compatibility                                                                       | Dynamic interaction (positive and negative feedback loops)         | Three-part trait-based motivational system                                        |
|--------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Dispositional change                                   | Surface CSV, deep CSC                                                   | Change-related traits are especially reliant on outcomes.                          | Change-related traits are especially relevant to interpersonal compatibility.                     | Change-related traits are especially generative of feedback loops. | Change-related traits are more motivational in dynamic environments.              |
| Person–situation interactions, situational specificity | Tracking CSV requires tracking of changes in situation trait relevance. | Bidirectionality within jobs, dissatisfaction from opposing trait-relevant demands | Fit with team members (chemistry) beyond fit with teamwork (per se), team tasks, and/or team role | Cross-trait activation chains: Trait A → Trait B                   | Dynamic trait activation = dynamic motivation                                     |
| Personality states                                     | States as proximate mediators of short-term trait effects               | Momentary performance, bidirectionality of state effects                           | Fluidity of interpersonal interactions and the agility of states versus traits                    | Emotional contagion as a positive feedback loop                    | States are motivational in the short term.                                        |
| Personality and career development                     | Social investment, promotions, turnover, vocational interests           | Employment stages, the Peter principle                                             | Political skill and career success                                                                | People make the place. Organizational life cycles                  | Person–workplace fit, theory of work adjustment, RIASEC, ASA                      |
| Self-regulation (SR)                                   | Traits as moderators of change mechanisms in SR processes               | Both SR and TAT rely on the behavior/performance distinction.                      | Self in context, trait as process, process as trait expression                                    | Feedback loops distinct but compatible in SR and TAT               | Traits as needs SR and TAT share reliance on affect as the fundamental motivator. |

Abbreviations: ASA, attraction–selection–attrition; CSC, cross-situational consistency (in behavior); CSV, cross-situational variability; RIASEC, realistic, investigative, artistic, social, enterprising, conventional; SR, self-regulation.

TAT separates behavior and performance for two reasons. First, it configures bidirectional (i.e., positive versus negative) trait–performance linkages as trait-expressive behavior yielding oppositely valued outcomes depending on work demands. Second, it isolates the role of observers whose evaluations convert one to the other. Change-related traits play into those processes like other traits: Flexibility may be positively or negatively related to observers’ evaluations of performance per local demands (Lievens et al. 2018). More so than other traits, however, those focusing on change have stronger intrinsic ties to outcomes. Self-monitoring, for example, entails adjusting one’s own behavioral style to accommodate others’ styles, requiring active monitoring of the exchange partner as a source of feedback guiding adjustments. Flexibility similarly relies on feedback as a basis for adjusting to changing demands. Understanding dynamic traits is especially reliant on the behavior/performance distinction.

TAT suggests people are compatible when they provide one another opportunities to express their traits in positively valued ways. Change-related traits lend themselves readily to this interactional process. Over brief or lengthy periods, two neurotic coworkers might reciprocate in elevating their negative affect, undermining work engagement and possibly their performance (each serving, in TAT terms, as a distracter for the other). The two might prefer the calming (i.e., constraining) influence of a more emotionally stable teammate. And, where the neurotics heighten the demand for stability, the preference may be mutual. The self-monitor feeds on change, each new social encounter offering a fresh opportunity for accommodation. Change-oriented dispositions add dynamic complexity to social interactions, and TAT can help model that complexity.

Behavioral effects on situations are advanced in TAT in terms of positive and negative feedback loops. Two neurotics recursively triggering one another's negative affect is understandable as a positive feedback loop (with typically negative outcomes); positive feedback can also occur with extraverts whose trait expressions invite further social engagement. Social interactions are prime settings for feedback loops: Arguments escalate, negotiations settle, and brainstorming sessions peak and subside. At a broader level, a Machiavellian leader might capitalize on organizational politics, promoting a culture with further opportunities for selfish manipulation. Proactive workers, offering suggestions in a suitably supportive environment (C. Brown, unpublished information), can stimulate further opportunity for change. Expressing any trait can alter future trait-expression opportunities; change-based traits are especially generative in this respect.

TAT holds that trait expression is intrinsically motivational. Change-based dispositions, accordingly, should be especially motivating in dynamic jobs, groups, and cultures where cues for change are abundant. TAT posits further motivation from extrinsic rewards contingent on trait expression, especially when outcomes are trait aligned. Thus, the adventurous worker might be especially motivated by an opportunity for an overseas placement or extended travel. Other extrinsic motivators relevant to those with change-related traits include increased learning opportunities (i.e., through training) and new assignments, coworkers, and technology. Organizations are dynamic systems. Where jobs, teams, and cultures are especially dynamic, change-focused traits are likely to play a more prominent role in worker motivation.

### **Trait Activation Theory and Person–Situation Interactions**

Person–situation interactions are the main focus of TAT, making TAT applications to personality dynamics in this respect somewhat redundant with earlier coverage. Going beyond the main thrust of TAT, however, is recognition that, as situations change over time, so too does the relevance of personality traits (Woods et al. 2013).

Behavioral variability across situations is, in part, a function of changing trait-relevant cues. At one moment, a situation might call for attention to detail as an expression of conscientiousness, and at the next, for creativity as an expression of openness. Tracking changes in behavior across situations from a personality dynamics perspective calls for tracking of corresponding changes in situational features affecting trait expression and its value.

Bidirectionality in personality–outcome linkages, evident between jobs (see Tett et al. 1999, Tett & Christiansen 2007), can also occur within jobs. An agreeable team leader, for example, might shine one minute in helping a deserving team member, but falter in the next, too easily accommodating an unproductive loafer. Trait expression in this case remains constant, but the value of that expression has changed. Should the agreeable leader manage an appropriately tough response to the loafer, TAT predicts they will experience dissatisfaction (Christiansen et al. 2014). Furthermore, if the demand for toughness becomes routine, the agreeable leader might seek a more agreeable job (in both senses of that term). Behavioral consistency yielding variable performance and behavioral variability yielding consistent but possibly dissatisfying performance are predictable only by separating trait-expressive behavior from its value as performance.

Interpersonal relationships are fluid: The nature of a given dyad, group, or team evolves over very brief to extended intervals. TAT offers to clarify the role of personality traits in team processes by focusing on team chemistry in terms of mutual trait activation. A well-functioning team, from a TAT perspective, is one where each member's traits are aligned not only with being a "team player" (Driskell et al. 2006) and with the team's mission (e.g., task type) and their particular role on the team (e.g., leader, gate keeper, devil's advocate), but also with their teammates' traits such that each member brings out the best in one another in contributing to the team's success.

Lykourantzou et al. (2016) found teams balanced in dominant and submissive members outperformed and were more satisfied than teams overloaded with dominant members. Humphrey et al. (2007) report similar complementarity involving extraversion broadly. Change was not a key focus in either study, but team outcomes seem likely to vary with changes in team member personality composition. Even with static team membership, evolving task demands can trigger different traits, each creating demands, distracters, constraints, etc., for other members in a cascade of trait activation, potentially affecting a variety of team processes and outcomes (see Driskell & Salas 2013).

Behavioral effects on situations are an especially dynamic part of TAT. Research on the proposed positive (cue-increasing) and negative (cue-decreasing) feedback loops is only beginning (Liguori et al. 2013, Sung et al. 2014). Operating in dynamic personality systems, such trait-behavior-situation-trait loops can be extended between traits. For example, conscientiousness successfully expressed as high performance may prompt recognition and social obligations relevant to extraversion. Openness expressed as war correspondence could increase demands for emotional stability. The possibilities for such cross-trait activation, especially at the facet level, seem endless. Whether some chains are more common than others and under what conditions (e.g., operational level) they emerge are questions for programmatic, longitudinal investigation.<sup>14</sup>

Need-based motivation can contribute to personality dynamics in light of situational complexities in trait-relevant cues. Consider, for example, two friends competing for the same promotion such that one's personal success risks estrangement from the other. Here, the needs for achievement and power might be pitted against the needs for affiliation and approval. Further motivational input derives from trait-influenced perceptions of extrinsic rewards (e.g., increased pay). How hard each friend competes for the promotion will be based, in part, on the net motivational force each derives from need fulfillment if one versus the other is promoted. Now consider that friend A offers B a hint of permission, partially satisfying B's affiliative need, favoring the competitive option. Alternatively, A might threaten B with the loss of friendship, thereby heightening B's affiliative need, favoring acquiescence. Other traits could be activated as well (e.g., aggression, autonomy), each contributing its own motivational force, depending on the individual's trait standings. Traits, as needs, are rudimentary motivational constructs, and motivational dynamics calls for their consideration in light of the flux of trait-relevant cues.

### **Trait Activation Theory and Personality States**

A key target of personality dynamics is personality states (e.g., Debusscher et al. 2016), which are relatively brief thoughts and feelings giving rise to behavior in response to particular situations or occasions. TAT was intended to model situational effects on trait expression, but it readily extends to personality states. Whole-trait theory (Fleeson 2012, Fleeson & Jayawickreme 2015) models relatively short-term fluctuations in personality states as density distributions of underlying dispositions. How might TAT advance such models?

TAT proposes that behavior is consistent across situations to the degree those situations are similarly trait relevant and trait expressions yield similarly valued outcomes. Because states are typically taken as indicators of intrapersonal variability, consistency in states across occasions is

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<sup>14</sup>The overall independence of the FFM dimensions suggests cross-activation may be equivocal at the broad level; by the same token, correlated facets within broad dimensions may reflect cross-activation at the facet level, e.g., detail orientation and achievement under conscientiousness, dominance and sociability under extraversion, and empathy and nurturance under agreeableness.

rarely the subject of investigation (see Fleeson & Law 2015 for an exception).<sup>15</sup> Extending the trait-relevance principle, states might be expected to recur to the degree occasions are similarly state relevant. Thus, states may be subject to the same basic activation processes involving traits, but on shorter timelines, with traits setting stochastic limits on state variability (Fleeson & Jayawickreme 2015).

TAT's taxonomy of situational features seems applicable as well, as situations can include momentary demands, distracters, constraints, releasers, facilitators, and discretionary cues, each affecting the generation and/or value of relevant states. States may be induced independently of traits (e.g., Minbashian et al. 2010), but underlying dispositions increase the likelihood of corresponding states. Thus, states are, to some degree, proximate mediators of trait effects that help explain short-term within-person variability (Debusscher et al. 2016).

The separation of behavior and performance frames bidirectionality and performance judgment relating to traits. It is of similar import in the context of states. Just as situational demands triggering traits over longer durations help frame performance judgments (in terms of how well demands are met), shorter-term demands eliciting states can frame judgments of momentary performance (Debusscher et al. 2016). Bidirectionality, accordingly, is possible with states as with traits (Heidemeier & Bittner 2012).

States offer considerable advantage in exploring the dynamics of interpersonal relationships. Two people can be getting along until one triggers an insecurity in the other, which might then be smoothed over by an apology or a vote of confidence. Such momentary shifts in behavior, affect, and cognition require constructs more nimble than trait dispositions, whose effects are evident across relatively long intervals where aggregation serves reliability and longer-term prediction (Epstein 1979, Fleeson 2004). States offer the needed agility for dealing with moment-to-moment variability in the quality of interpersonal exchanges, as short-term trait proxies.

The shortened timeline on which states vary lends itself to consideration of behavioral effects on situations over brief intervals. Emotional contagion has been linked to emotional stability/neuroticism: Those higher on neuroticism are more susceptible to negative emotion transfer and those higher on emotional stability, to positive emotion transfer (see Barsade et al. 2018). These effects can be understood as positive feedback loops in emotional stability/neuroticism activation, leading to negative versus positive mood states (Sy & Choi 2013). Variables preventing or extinguishing contagion permit configuration in terms of negative feedback loops (e.g., positive affect defusing negative affect contagion). Trait-based motivational states (Bipp & Kleinbeck 2011) also permit configuration as feedback loops in dynamic interaction.

States, more so than traits, have affective content (Seo et al. 2004). Some states are pleasurable, others noxious. People willingly engage with situations and other people that evoke more positive states and avoid those evoking more negative states. Also, behavior that expresses a given state might be expected to be intrinsically motivating (i.e., cathartic), and expectations of positive outcomes (e.g., a favorable reaction from a friend, a negative reaction from a rival) are also likely to drive whether or not a state is acted on. Motivational processes involving states seem largely parallel to those involving traits modeled under TAT, albeit operating on shorter timelines.

## **Trait Activation Theory and Personality and Career Development**

Whereas personality states play out over very brief intervals, dynamic personality processes are also evident on the scale of years, decades, and lifespans. TAT was not intended for application

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<sup>15</sup>We thank Filip Lievens for bringing this to our attention.

over such intervals. Here, we explore some possibilities regarding career dynamics, promotion, and turnover, which occur over relatively extended timelines.

Consistent with evolutionary processes promoting survival and reproductive success, aging brings with it increasing demands for ambition, responsibility, and leadership. Roberts et al.'s (2005) social investment principle holds that age-dependent social norms drive upward population shifts on conscientiousness, dominance, emotional stability, and agreeableness. Similarly, Wille et al. (2012) reported normative trait shifts relating to career roles adopted over 15 post-college years. Mean neuroticism, for example, decreased in those serving in director, presenter, or inspirator roles. Woods et al. (2013) suggest such shifts may reflect habitual trait activation, relevant to personality dynamics on the scale of populations spanning decades.

Targeting individual-level variability, Ng et al. (2005) report meta-analytic mean  $\rho$ s for linkages between promotion frequency and neuroticism ( $-0.11$ ), extraversion ( $0.18$ ), and proactive personality ( $0.16$ ). From an interactionist perspective, these results suggest promotion opportunities trigger avoidance in neurotic workers versus engagement in extroverted and proactive workers. Zimmerman (2008) reports meta-analytic estimates of linkages between turnover and the FFM. The strongest relationships are with agreeableness (mean  $\rho = -0.27$ ), conscientiousness ( $-0.22$ ), and emotional stability ( $-0.20$ ),<sup>16</sup> suggesting workers are more likely to quit, in general, when prone to fitting poorly with coworkers, work standards, and work stressors, respectively. Results of both studies show a role for personality in within-person job change at a general level, but they ignore effects involving individuals' particular trait-based vocational preferences.

Holland's (1997) RIASEC (realistic, investigative, artistic, social, enterprising, conventional) model holds that job and career choices are an extension of personality: "people tend to act on their dominant interests and seek occupations in which their interests can be expressed" (Holland 1996, p. 400). Consistent with this gravitational hypothesis, Judge et al. (1999) reported people tend to work in jobs aligned with their personality traits (e.g.,  $r$  between childhood extraversion and social job employment =  $0.20$ ). Similarly, De Fruyt & Mervielde (1999) found college students' RIASEC interests and FFM traits predicted RIASEC-aligned job employment a year after graduation. Extraversion, for example, correlated  $0.35$  with employment in enterprising jobs and  $0.25$  in social jobs. People take jobs for other reasons, most notably, to pay for life's necessities, and for other practical reasons (e.g., location, work schedule). Personality-job incongruence feeds career instability (Holland 1996, 1997). As skills and fit opportunities improve over the lifespan, stability increases (Gottfredson 1977). Holland's interactionist model readily accommodates trait activation in accounting for the dynamics of individual career trajectories.

Considering personality-performance relationships over time raises key issues regarding separation of trait-expressive behavior and its value. Woods et al. (2013) note how performance follows a learning curve, plateaus, then gradually declines (Zyphur et al. 2008) and how different personality traits predict performance at different employment stages (Murphy 1989). Thoresen et al. (2004) found openness and agreeableness predict sales performance improvement in the early transition stage, when learning and networking are important, whereas conscientiousness predicts in the later maintenance stage, when task goals matter more. Similarly, Lievens et al. (2009) report bidirectional trait effects in a medical school setting, where extraversion predicted early performance negatively and later performance positively. TAT offers two sources for such

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<sup>16</sup>These point-biserial correlations are corrected for range restriction, unreliability, and uneven splits on turnover; they are not corrected for dichotomization per se. Accordingly, upper and lower limits are  $\pm 0.80$ . Estimates on the full  $\pm 1.00$  correlation range may be derived by dividing reported estimates by  $0.80$  (e.g.,  $-0.27/0.80 = -0.34$ ).

stage-specific effects: differences in (a) trait-expression opportunities and/or (b) the value of a given trait's expression. Longitudinal study distinguishing those two mechanisms could shed light on the dynamics of personality–performance linkages as a function of employment stage.

The Peter principle (Peter & Hull 1969) describes how top performers are promoted to positions where they fail. Success as a mid-level software engineer, for example, favors independence, introversion, and detail orientation (Cruz et al. 2015). Management, in contrast, calls for cooperation, assertiveness, and big-picture thinking (Acuna et al. 2006; see Smith et al. 1985). Transitioning from one to the next challenges fit. Benson et al. (2019) showed recently that companies tend to promote their most productive salespeople to management and suffer net losses when they do. Organizations fare better when promoting candidates with collaboration experience relevant to managerial demands. Although not expressly about personality, this study shows how promotion can turn strengths into liabilities. From a TAT perspective, the two jobs vary in opportunities for trait expression and/or the value of those expressions (i.e., demands in one may be distracters in the other). Separating trait expression from its value as performance offers insight into the Peter principle from an interactionist standpoint.

Research on the role of interpersonal compatibility in career advancement is limited. Munyon et al. (2015) reported meta-analytic linkages between political skill, defined as “interpersonal savvy and style” (p. 144), and the FFM and various work outcomes. Notable mean  $\rho$ s were obtained with extraversion (0.48), agreeableness (0.28), conscientiousness (0.24), emotional stability (0.23), and career success (i.e., income and position level; mean  $\rho = 0.27$ ). Extraversion, the strongest correlate of political skill, is a driver for advancement (e.g., Costa & McCrae 1988). The other three, agreeableness, conscientiousness, and emotional stability, identify Digman's (1997) “socialization” factor, labeled “stability” by DeYoung (2006). Putting all this together from a TAT perspective, advancement opportunities are cues for extraversion, and being high, in addition, on agreeableness, conscientiousness, and emotional stability contributes to political skill fostering a favorable reputation as a socialized, stable, and humbly ambitious promotion candidate (Munyon et al. 2015). Zimmerman's (2008) mean  $\rho$  of  $-0.27$  between agreeableness and turnover, noted above, affords a comparable interpretation in the direction opposite promotion. More direct tests of trait-based interpersonal compatibility in career dynamics await investigation.

Countering situationist claims that behavior is dictated by situations, Schneider (1987) argued, “the people make the place.” A leader's disposition, for example, can drive organizational culture, which, in turn, influences worker behavior via company policies and reward structure. This is consistent with dynamic interaction in TAT, whereby trait expression affects the availability of further trait-relevant cues.

Changes in leadership demands across the business life cycle offer an extension of such feedback loops. Lippitt & Schmidt (1967) describe three stages of an organization's life cycle, each with its own concerns: birth (creation, viability), youth (stability, reputation), and maturity (adaptability, societal contribution). The relevance of leader personality traits might be expected to change as the organization grows. From a TAT perspective, traits operating successfully in earlier stages could decrease demands for those traits later on. Zhao & Seibert (2006) report meta-analytic standardized mean differences between entrepreneurs and managers on several traits, including achievement ( $\delta = 0.59$ ), openness (0.36), and neuroticism ( $-0.37$ ). To the degree the entrepreneur/manager distinction tracks transitions along the organization life cycle, these differences support dynamic interaction: Achievement, openness, and emotional stability (i.e., low neuroticism) successfully engaged during start-up move the organization to a stage with reduced demands for those qualities. Longitudinal tracking of leaders' trait-relevant demands (distracters, constraints, etc.) operating at different levels across organizational life cycles would more directly illuminate dynamic personality effects in the workplace.



Trait-based work motivation spanning careers and lifespans is most readily consolidated in terms of person–workplace fit. The theory of work adjustment (Dawis & Lofquist 1976, 1984) identifies adjustment as “the continuous and dynamic process by which the individual seeks to achieve and maintain correspondence with his or her work environment” (Dawis & Lofquist 1976, p. 55). Work situations are differentiated by their “occupational reinforcers,” which are conditions that satisfy the worker’s needs (Dawis & Lofquist 1975). Holland’s (1997) RIASEC model similarly suggests individuals are drawn to and motivated by occupations that align with their personality and interests (Sullivan & Hansen 2004). Schneider’s (1987; Schneider et al. 1995, 1998) attraction–selection–attrition (ASA) model holds that people are attracted to, selected into, and stay with or leave an organization based on personality similarity. All those models, like TAT, frame worker motivation based on fit. TAT expands on this idea in several ways.

First, TAT emphasizes traits as needs (Murray 1938). The theory of work adjustment (Dawis & Lofquist 1984) considers needs as bases for work values more so than traits (Hansen 2013). Satisfying needs through trait expression, per TAT, is intrinsically rewarding (i.e., pleasurable; see, e.g., Smillie 2013). Second, adopting basic behaviorist principles, TAT adds motivational force from extrinsic rewards contingent on performance and further conditions that motivation on the degree to which reward type is relevant to the worker’s traits (differential reward preference). Distinguishing intrinsic and extrinsic motivation sets up the possibility of conflict between them: Fit is especially poor where cues abound for negatively valued traits. Third, TAT identifies three levels of situational features offering opportunity for fit: task, group, and organizational. Finally, TAT suggests performance feedback should be especially motivating to those high on achievement striving. All told, TAT holds that career dynamics, punctuated by turnover and promotions, are a function of the individual’s long-term pursuit of a job in which they are rewarded for being themselves.

### **Trait Activation Theory and Self-Regulation**

SR denotes “processes involved in attaining and maintaining (i.e., keeping regular) goals, where goals are internally represented (i.e., within the self) desired states” (Vancouver & Day 2005, p. 158). Motivation derives from the gap between targeted and current selves, operationalized by the goal–performance discrepancy (Lord et al. 2010). Similar to traits, goals are activated by situational input, but through schema-driven processes (Carver & Scheier 1990).

Dispositions are secondary to cognitive mechanisms in SR models, albeit important in some. They are invoked most often in terms of goal orientation [i.e., mastery, performance approach, performance avoidance (VandeWalle 1997; see Donovan et al. 2013)], but other traits, too, including conscientiousness (e.g., Diefendorff et al. 1998, Roberts et al. 2005), anxiety (Kanfer & Heggestad 1997), and impulsivity (Shah et al. 2002). Promoting a broad interface between personality traits and SR processes, DeYoung’s (2015) cybernetic Big Five theory identifies the FFM dimensions specifically in terms of their relevance to goal-driven motivation. Conscientiousness, for example, drives prioritization of long-term goals over immediate gratification, extraversion drives sensitivity to rewards, and neuroticism, sensitivity to threats. Given this cursory introduction to SR and relevant traits, let us explore how TAT might be incorporated into SR theory.

SR theory targets variability in two main respects: Changes in task demands trigger SR processes by introducing or altering goals; furthermore, the individual adjusts effort, attention, and direction of behavior to close the gap between targeted and current selves (Lord et al. 2010). Overlaying this essentially universal process (i.e., applicable to everyone), dispositional tendencies (i.e., personality traits) can affect the trajectory of that process (DeYoung 2015, Hooker & McAdams 2003). Achievement-oriented people tend to set harder performance goals (Seijts et al. 2004) and try harder to meet goals (Barrick et al. 1993), impulsive individuals are more easily distracted

from their goals (Shah et al. 2002), and anxious workers tend to orient performance away from the task, toward the self (Simpson et al. 2001, Vancouver & Tischner 2004). Given (a) SR is focused on variability in situational inputs, behavioral outputs, and cognitive–affective mediators and (b) personality traits predispose behaviors affecting relations among those variables, then (c) understanding what activates, constrains, releases, and facilitates relevant dispositions and the levels at which such factors operate (task, group, organization) advances understanding of within-person variability in work motivation through a SR lens (Donovan et al. 2013).

SR theory, as with TAT, clearly distinguishes behavior from performance, offering several points of comparison between the two theories. First, performance in SR is goal attainment, whereas in TAT it is behavior that meets work demands. Goals, although similar to demands, are cognitive constructs, whereas demands are external work features. Second, performance feedback is fundamental to SR (e.g., DeShon et al. 2004); in TAT, it is expected to be especially salient to those higher on achievement striving. Third, the distinction offered in TAT as a basis for explaining bidirectional trait–performance relationships has similar application in SR. Hoyle (2006) notes impulsivity tends to undermine goal processes but is sometimes beneficial (Dickman 1990). SR models expand opportunity for bidirectionality by articulating mediated pathways to performance. Bipp & Kleinbeck (2011), for example, found participants higher in neuroticism had lower expectancy but higher goal commitment on a difficult task. Fourth, TAT also separates behavior and performance to invite consideration of the active role of performance judges. To our knowledge, SR models neither consider this [as distinct from the active role of supervisors in the goal-setting process (e.g., Lord & Brown 2004)] nor preclude it. All told, TAT and SR are compatible by their separation of behavior and performance, albeit with different emphases and applications of that distinction.

Morf (2006) noted in the context of SR that “the self is completely contextualized in the social environment with which it is constantly engaged” (pp. 1530–32). Narcissists devalue others whose higher performance is perceived as threatening (Morf & Rhodewalt 1993), and workers higher on dependency anxiously reject well-meaning attempts by others to promote their autonomy (Bornstein 2005). In TAT terms, others’ successes are a distracter for narcissism, and withdrawal of support is a distracter for dependency. As with TAT, SR has rarely been applied to the study of workplace relationships [as distinct from SR understood as operating in a social context—e.g., goal contagion (Aarts et al. 2008)—see Liu et al. 2015 for an exception]. Hoyle (2006) suggests such SR applications “require the thoughtful integration of temperament, personality, and information-processing constructs in such a way that traits can be understood in terms of process and processes can be understood as expressions of traits” (p. 1516). TAT is well positioned to advance SR approaches to understanding interpersonal relationships along those lines.

Lord et al. (2010) describe SR as a negative feedback loop in which goal-directed behavior narrows the goal–performance discrepancy, decreasing motivation. Conversely, in a positive feedback loop, a widening gap increases motivation. This is similar to the negative and positive feedback loops in TAT, whereby a given trait’s expression reduces or increases further activation. The difference is that the gap in Lord et al.’s model is cognitive and self-based, whereas in TAT, cues are aspects of the situation. The two pairs of feedback loops are not interchangeable, but neither are they incompatible. Dispositions operating on SR pathways might promote or inhibit further trait expression. Unchecked impulsivity, for example, could create a cycle of distraction, each rabbit hole leading to another. Narcissists, ironically, create conditions that hamper their future success, triggering further self-embellishment (Morf 2006). Generalized self-efficacy might also operate on a positive loop, but with more favorable outcomes. Achievement striving serving goal completion may be on a negative loop in the short run but on a positive loop over longer intervals if early

successes invite new achievement opportunities. As dynamic systems, SR models incorporating dispositions seem primed to accommodate dynamic trait–situation interactions framed by TAT.

Motivation is the *raison d'être* of SR, whereas in TAT, it is a driver of trait-based situational engagement as a foundation for person–workplace fit (Tett et al. 2013). The theories differ further in the nature of motivation they prescribe. In SR, motivation derives from the current–ideal–self discrepancy. Positive affect (i.e., satisfaction) ensues from closing the gap, and negative affect, from corresponding threats. Motivation in TAT derives primarily from need satisfaction (Christiansen et al. 2014, Murray 1938), whereby trait expression is inherently satisfying.<sup>17</sup> Further satisfaction may derive from knowledge of results, especially where success satisfies the need for achievement, and from extrinsic outcomes, especially those aligned with relevant traits.

Notably, affect is the fundamental common denominator of motivation in both theories. SR theories positing dispositions as moderators (including DeYoung's cybernetic theory) offer no rationale for why such dispositions are engaged except in service to reducing the goal–performance discrepancy. Traits such as impulsivity impede discrepancy reduction, and it is unclear what motivational mechanism might derive from SR to explain its engagement. From a TAT perspective, responding impulsively to opportunities for distraction provides the impulsive worker intrinsic satisfaction from need fulfillment.<sup>18</sup> To the degree impulsivity undermines performance, satisfaction from trait expression will conflict with others' negative reactions and associated outcomes. Thus, a job with many distractions offers an especially poor fit to someone high on impulsivity. By the same basic process, jobs with clear, challenging goals offer good fit to workers high on conscientiousness; those with goals requiring positive, active social engagement offer good fit to those high on extraversion, and so forth.

There is no reason in principle why cognitive, self-based discrepancies and trait-based needs cannot coexist in a hybrid SR–TAT motivational system. Each motivational process contributes uniquely to work motivation. Furthermore, both reduce to affect, driving approach and avoidance responses to the environment, in turn, serving fit in the immediate timeframe and, ultimately, survival and reproductive success.

## SUMMARY AND FUTURE DIRECTIONS

Trait activation theory was offered as a call to action in furthering predictive gains from personality in light of identifiable complexities in trait–situation interactions, and this aim, on the whole, appears to have been met. Our review of the TAT literature spanning 2011 to 2019, extending Tett et al.'s (2013) review, suggests person–situation interactions, situational specificity, and situation trait relevance are increasingly recognized as critical in understanding the role of personality at work. Further recognized are the ideas that such interactions play out at multiple levels (task, group, organization, and, recently, national culture), through mechanisms involving trait-specific work demands, distracters, constraints, releasers, and discretionary cues, and, in some cases, with motivational impact of traits as needs. The theory has been used to advance understanding of those and various related topics, including person–workplace fit, personality-oriented work analysis, team-building, performance appraisal, trait-specific work autonomy, trait and criterion specificity, behavioral effects on situations (i.e., dynamic interaction), complex interactions involving

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<sup>17</sup>Neuroticism works a little differently than other traits (Costa & McCrae 1988) by motivating threat avoidance (e.g., DeYoung 2015). Neurotics do not enjoy feeling worried, angry, and depressed, but they enjoy reductions in those feelings when neuroticism-driven avoidance diminishes precipitating cues.

<sup>18</sup>Notwithstanding any negative consequences, impulsive people enjoy jumping from one thing to the next.

multiple traits and situational factors, situational taxonomies, the role of nontrait predictors (e.g., KSAs, motives, values), and complementary theories. Significance rates for theory-driven moderator tests provide overall support for situation trait relevance and for TAT as a generative and integrative framework.

Mapping TAT onto the personality dynamics literature shows opportunity to extend application of TAT-framed interactionist principles in advancing understanding of within-person variability in terms of change-focused dispositions, person–situation interactions, personality states, career paths, and SR motivation models. Corresponding literatures offer varying support for such applications (e.g., emotional contagion, the Peter principle, ASA), but much more is possible. We close our review by highlighting five synergistic research vectors where TAT seems most likely to yield predictive and theoretic gains.

### **Personality-Oriented Work Analysis**

It is approaching 30 years since Tett et al. (1991) reported notably stronger personality validity estimates based on job analysis as a refined confirmatory strategy. Personality-oriented work analysis has been advanced (e.g., Raymark et al. 1997) with overall success (e.g., Aguinis et al. 2009, O'Neill et al. 2013), and most prominent personality tests have companion work analysis instruments. Yet, relatively few empirical studies have leveraged such tools to identify traits especially likely to predict under local conditions (Goffin et al. 2011). The call for trait-based work analysis is a timely one, not only in support of local validation (e.g., for selection) but also programmatically in studies of personality dynamics, where trait-relevant cues shift over varying timescales, activating and deactivating traits within and among individuals, and affecting complex motivational processes with diverse behavioral and affective outcomes. Now, more than ever, we need measures to track the cues, constraints, and facilitators operating at multiple levels as conditions affecting when and how targeted traits (and states) are expressed in valued ways.<sup>19</sup>

### **Longitudinal Studies of Personality Processes**

Increased reliance on personality-oriented work analysis complements the need for longitudinal investigation of the person–situation relationship as a two-way street (Wille et al. 2014): Situations trigger traits affecting situations relevant to the actor and others over minutes (e.g., negotiations) to decades (career paths). Time introduces unique situational factors, including cue stability, modulation (e.g., daily routines, seasonal markets), and density (e.g., cues per minute). It elevates the importance of states and time-related traits, such as endurance, impulsivity, and conservatism, and offers points of comparison among task, social, organizational, and national levels, operating on successively extended timelines. Recognizing time-linked factors on both sides of the person–situation linkage creates unique opportunities for interactions from a dynamic, longitudinal perspective.

### **Within-Job Bidirectionality**

Bidirectionality of trait–outcome linkages between jobs is well established (Tett & Christiansen 2007). Its occurrence within jobs is less clear, but few traits have universally positive or negative expressions even within jobs. People are hired to meet dominant work demands, but how do they deal with the distracters? Can a positive predictor of one performance dimension (e.g., budget

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<sup>19</sup>Meyer et al. (2014) introduced a measure of situational strength, showing moderation of personality relationships with OCB and CWB due to differential situational strength, independently of trait relevance.

management) be a negative predictor of another (e.g., charismatic leadership)? Are such traits weakly related to overall performance (due to cancelation of positive and negative effects), and is this practically equivalent to where trait-relevant cues are lacking altogether? Are curvilinear relationships more likely where strong demands operate at both poles of the trait? How do workers navigate conflicting demands operating at different levels (task, group, etc.)? Do traits such as self-monitoring and functional flexibility help in this respect? Is job crafting the active promotion of demands and reduction of distracters relevant to one's traits, moderated perhaps by proactive personality? TAT provides a suitably articulated frame for viewing these and related questions through an interactionist lens.

### **Trait Activation in Teams**

Teams are dynamic systems (e.g., Salas et al. 1992). TAT identifies four distinct opportunities for differential trait effects in team settings: (*a*) team orientation (being a “team player”) in meeting overall team-driven demands to engage and help teammates (extraversion, agreeableness), meet commitments (conscientiousness), and adapt to change (emotional stability, openness); (*b*) team task types (e.g., interdependence increasing demands for cooperation and agreeableness; a think tank, for creative thinking); (*c*) team member roles (e.g., leadership increasing demands for dominance; devil's advocate, for assertiveness); and (*d*) team member relationships as mutual trait activation serving both complementary (e.g., dominance/submissiveness) and supplementary (e.g., sociability/sociability) fit. Traits activated in one respect may affect trait expressions and their value in another. TAT can help manage such complexities in teamwork involving dispositions, related states, and other variables (e.g., KSAs, values) by reliance on a common set of principles, including situational relevance, dynamic interaction, and need-based motivation.

### **Person–Workplace Fit and Situational Relevance**

The common target of all major strategies in work psychology is person–workplace fit, yielding both performance and worker well-being (Tett et al. 2013). Applying TAT to traits, KSAs, and values operating at multiple levels promotes integration of fit under common principles. KSAs meet task demands as complementary fit serving performance and operate similarly at the social/team level. Conversely, values are targets of supplementary fit with culture and climate at the organizational level serving positive work attitudes (e.g., job satisfaction) and operate similarly at the social/team level. Personality traits operate at all three levels: Meeting task demands in complementary fit serves performance, matching organizational characteristics in supplementary fit serves positive work attitudes, and both complementary and supplementary fit at the social/team level serve performance and positive attitudes. Tying together all those fit variants is the principle of situational relevance, the heart of TAT. TAT-based personality-oriented work analysis tuned to trait-specific demands, distracters, etc., operating at multiple levels (task, social, etc.) and engaged over time in longitudinal designs promises to improve trait-based prediction of valued outcomes, set boundary conditions on generalizability inferences, and expand our understanding of personality and companion constructs in the workplace and beyond.

### **EPILOGUE**

Such is the state of the trait activation literature spanning 2011–2019, with a view to new applications in the emerging domain of personality dynamics and some especially promising projections of the situation trait-relevance principle. At the broadest level, this review confirms what

most industrial–organizational psychologists already know: Situations matter. Why and how they matter, particularly regarding the role of personality at work, is less straightforward. TAT, so far, appears to offer both an integrative and generative framework for advancing programmatic research into person–situation interactions serving both practical and theoretic aims. Its future seems bright; time will tell.

## DISCLOSURE STATEMENT

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